These are the facts: decent at golf, useful at rugby and tennis when I was young, and enjoying cricket ever since. The errors will doubtless remain on the Internet and people will continue to believe I was some kind of prodigy at all those different sports, but the truth will hopefully somehow endure.

With all this said, I remain extremely grateful for the good fortune to be born with a natural ability to play sport, but ability only takes you so far. There are tens of thousands of talented sports people who never realise their full potential because it is ability plus opportunity that generally equals sporting success, and, for me, the opportunity to play sport, initially for fun and subsequently for a living, was presented by my parents.

They never interfered with coaches, never pushed me and never put pressure on me, but my father made substantial financial sacrifices that enabled me to play and my mother provided endless, selfless, unconditional support, driving me to so many training sessions and to so many matches and standing on touchlines; in tennis, she took on the responsibility of being my coach as well.

Millie de Villiers has always managed to find 25 hours in every day. Aside from taking care of her husband and her three sons and keeping the family home in order, she worked as an estate agent in Bela-Bela and still found the time to spend two or three afternoons each week coaching young tennis players.

Our entire family enjoyed tennis, playing at the local sports club – we called it 'the club at the end of the road' even though it was three kilometres from our home – and watching all the Grand Slam tournaments on TV. The stars of the game were our heroes. Steffi Graf, the German who won the Wimbledon women's singles title seven times between 1988 and 1996, was perhaps the greatest sweetheart in our house.

My older brothers, Jan and Wessels, played tennis and in June 1990 both were entered to play in a tournament known as the Lowveld Open in Nelspruit. My mother had seen me hit the ball while playing at the